

# The Roberts Line

*A research summary, prepared for the family. Naperville, Illinois, February 2026.*

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## Purpose

This binder traces the Roberts family from its probable Welsh origin to the present, gathering records, documenting relatives, and preserving the stories before the people who carry them are gone. The rule of the project is simple: nothing enters the tree as fact until a primary source holds it. Family stories are logged as leads, not truth, and a name with a single source stays marked probable until a second source agrees.

## The confirmed line

Four generations are now documented. Thomas Roberts, an ironworker out of Merthyr Tydfil in Wales, is the probable immigrant ancestor, arriving through the port of New York in 1891. His son Walter Roberts (1898 to 1967) worked as an iron molder in a Chicago foundry and raised his family at 2236 South Sawyer Avenue. Walter's son Raymond (1925 to 1998), a machinist and Army veteran, was my father. The trade runs iron, to iron, to the workbench in my garage.

| Generation        | Name               | Years             | Trade and place                           |
|-------------------|--------------------|-------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| Great-grandfather | Thomas Roberts     | arr. 1891 to 1936 | Ironworker, Merthyr Tydfil to Chicago     |
| Grandfather       | Walter Roberts     | 1898 to 1967      | Iron molder, South Sawyer Avenue, Chicago |
| Father            | Raymond J. Roberts | 1925 to 1998      | Machinist and Army veteran, Chicago       |
| Self              | Andrew J. Roberts  | b. 1955           | Mechanical engineer, Naperville           |

## Key findings this winter

- The 1930 and 1940 federal censuses both place Walter at the Sawyer Avenue address and give his occupation as iron molder, matching my father's stories almost word for word.
- The marriage record for Walter Roberts and Margaret Doyle, filed with the county clerk in November 1922, confirms the Doyle connection and names a witness, likely Margaret's brother.
- A baptismal register from a South Side parish records Raymond's birth in January 1925 with godparents named Doyle, a second thread tying the two families.
- A death certificate for Thomas Roberts, dated December 1936, lists his birthplace only as Wales and names his father as David Roberts, a new name for the file.

## Open questions

| Question                                              | Status      | Next action                                          |
|-------------------------------------------------------|-------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| Is the 1891 Merthyr Tydfil manifest truly our Thomas? | Probable    | Find a second corroborating record before accepting. |
| Did Walter appear in any foundry employment ledger?   | Open        | Awaiting reply from a South Side historic site.      |
| Who were Carol's Foster grandparents?                 | Not started | Begin the maternal line in the spring.               |

## Sources consulted

Federal census records for 1930 and 1940; county clerk marriage and death records; a South Side parish baptismal register; a passenger manifest index for the Liverpool to New York crossing; and a newspaper obituary clipping kept in the family file. Forty-one records are logged to date, twenty-eight of them held to a primary source. The full citations live in the research log.

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Kept by Andrew J. Roberts. For Meg, Tom, Lily, and Sam, when they are old enough to ask.